The raja prepares to cleanse himself in a giant gold pot, afterwards divided among the Brahmins.

It is recorded that in the course of one such *thulapurusha danam* ceremony conducted in 1850 around 22,900 *kalanju* of gold were distributed, of which the head priest of the Padmanabhaswamy temple and twenty-six officiating priests received 5731, Nambudiri lords 846, Nambudiri and Canarese Brahmins 4778, Tamil Brahmins 3666, Brahmin women and children 1243, other Brahmins 3707, and the rest 2867. One *kalanju* is roughly the equivalent of 3.2 grams, so over 73,000 grams or 2350 troy ounces were distributed.[2] If similar amounts of gold were donated at every *mahadanam* ceremony it is easy to understand how this led to the enrichment of the Brahmins and the growing impoverishment of the state.

This practice ended in 1850 when the then Governor of the Madras Presidency made an unofficial protest, warning the then ruling maharaja that if he continued to make these *mahadanam*s the Madras Presidency would intervene and he might well lose his throne. So the *mahadanam* ended – but not before Travancore had become a byword in India for caste prejudice and discrimination.

When Marthanda Varma died in 1758 he was succeeded by Kathika Thirunal Rama Varma, who became known as the Dharma Raja on account of his good government. He, too, had the sense to appoint two able administrators: as his *dalawa*, or Chief Minister, a Nair named Kesava Pillai, better known as Raja Kesavadas, and as his finance minister a wealthy Syrian Christian trader in timber and spices named Thachil Matthoo. With the addition of the Great General, this was a winning team that enabled the raja to repel the invading forces of Tipu Sultan of Mysore and to complete an ambitious construction project that saw Alleppey transformed into a major port and financial centre. At this same time the East India Company (EICo) became